

Animal Extinction in Australia

Societal problem definition, Databases project

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Australia is the planet's extinction hotspot, but one animal offers a glimmer of hope

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Tiffanie Turnbull
Dryandra, Western Australia

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"Eyes peeled," comes the order from the front passenger seat.

Obediently, we scan the ends and tops of logs, looking between low scrub and patches of vivid wildflowers for a flash of stripes or a dart of movement.

Eluding us is the numbat, a rare Australian marsupial which could be the love-child of a chipmunk and an anteater.

Numbats were once populous across the bottom half of the continent, but Dryandra Woodland – in the south-western corner of Australia – is one of the few places they remain.

As we slowly roll along bush tracks, researchers explain how this annual trip helps plot the

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Figure 1 Turnbull, T. (2026, August 8). Australia is the planet's extinction hotspot, but one animal offers a glimmer of hope. BBC News. <https://www.bbc.com/news>

Our group has chosen the problem of animal extinction in Australia, as we believe that this issue not only describes the problem of a loss in biodiversity that directly impacts ecosystems, but also demonstrates one of the many consequences of the climate change.

This issue is relevant to the general population as our group finds it vital to inform masses about the ramifications the loss of biodiversity imposes on the planet and all living organisms.

We believe that to have access to structured and logically organized data on this issue would be especially beneficial for nature conservation organizations and policymakers, who have the power to make a change in this field and act accordingly based on the insights derived from such data. Thus, our goal for this project – constructing a database that would effectively connect publicly available information about animal extinction in Australia including connecting information such as the climate conditions and presence of diseases, feral pests and urban development in the natural habitats of such species.

This topic was chosen based on the news article written by Tiffanie Turnbull that has been published on 08-08-2026 on BBC, which is a British public service broadcaster.

The article in whole can be found at: <https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/c9q94lxqrzzo>

The article describes challenges animals are facing not only in Australia. Such challenges, for example include the change in climate that forces the animals to migrate to different locations or that makes it hard for them to find food. Moreover, there are several diseases affecting Australia's species and together with the presence of predator species, urban development, timber harvesting and increasing natural disasters such as large-scale forest fires drive the alarming rate of the loss of species that the article claims to be about four species every decade with the decline worsening. The article also mentions that Australia has the highest

mammal extinction rate in the whole world. Furthermore, the article discusses past and present conservation efforts. Nonetheless, it is implied that such efforts do not currently match the severity of the situation.

The main stakeholders in this challenge are nature conservation organizations and policymakers. Conservation organizations need structured data to prioritize species, while policymakers need evidence to evaluate and design environmental legislation. Researchers are also direct users of such data, as connecting climate, disease, predator and habitat information could reveal patterns behind species decline. Further stakeholders include the general public, who are affected by biodiversity loss and can influence policy through awareness; Indigenous communities, who play an important role in land and wildlife management; and industries such as urban development, whose activities are linked to habitat loss.

Following peer-reviewed articles were read in order to understand and map some of the forces driving the loss of species in Australia. Such information will then later support our choices of entities in the Entity Relationship Diagram and provides evidence for the relationships we will be modelling in our database.

1) Investigating the Causes of an Extinction Catastrophe: Controlling Introduced Predators Remains Essential for Conserving Australia's Mammals, Woinarski et al., 2026 [1]

This [rebuttal article](#) provides evidence on for the link between the presence of predators, namely the domestic cat and red fox, and the extinction of Australian mammals.

2) Lots of loss with little scrutiny: The attrition of habitat critical for threatened species in Australia, Ward et al., 2019 [2]

This [research article](#) investigates the effectiveness of the EPBC Act that requires projects that could potentially affect the environment and biodiversity to be reported for assessment. The analysis was conducted based on data in 2000-2017 period. Moreover, and more importantly in the light of this project, the article calculates the potential loss of habitat for 1,638 terrestrial threatened species. In conclusion, 85% of these species has suffered some habitat loss.

3) Loss of terrestrial biodiversity in Australia: Magnitude, causation, and response, Sarah Legge et al., 2023 [3]

This [review article](#) outlines the main causes of Australian animal extinction, specifically focusing on how climate change and severe bushfires accelerate species loss. It highlights where current policies fail and identifies key gaps in monitoring endangered wildlife.

References:

- 1) J. C. Z. Woinarski et al., "Investigating the causes of an extinction catastrophe: Controlling introduced predators remains essential for conserving Australia's mammals," *BioScience*, vol. 76, no. 3, pp. 294–307, Mar. 2026, doi: 10.1093/biosci/biaf204.
- 2) M. S. Ward, J. S. Simmonds, A. E. Reside, J. E. M. Watson, J. R. Rhodes, H. P. Possingham, J. Trezise, R. Fletcher, L. File, and M. Taylor, "Lots of loss with little scrutiny: The attrition of habitat critical for threatened species in Australia," *Conservation Science and Practice*, vol. 1, no. 11, e117, 2019, doi: 10.1111/csp2.117.
- 3) Sarah Legge et al., Loss of terrestrial biodiversity in Australia: Magnitude, causation, and response. *Science* 381, 622-631(2023). DOI:10.1126/science.adg7870